

PlayNest Interview Analysis

Validating Aurora's Market Hypotheses Against a Second Category Player

Interview with Gabriel Paes Leme (Head of PlayNest, Play9 Group) • September 15, 2026 • Conducted and analyzed by Kaiane Souza

1. Purpose and Sources

This document consolidates the findings from a research interview conducted with Gabriel Paes Leme, who leads PlayNest within the Play9 group, one of the established players in the Brazilian creator economy. This is the second interview in Aurora's market validation round, following the earlier conversation with Creator Ads. Where the Creator Ads interview was held with a Go-to-Market Engineer and skewed toward operational and technical detail, this one was held directly with the executive leading the business, and skews toward company history, positioning, and relationship philosophy.

Four sources were used to build this analysis: (1) the interview question script, organized into five thematic blocks (market growth, client profile, automation, creator dynamics, and agency role); (2) personal notes taken during the conversation; (3) an automatically generated meeting summary; and (4) the full interview transcript. The summary and transcript were both delivered in a single Gemini-generated document. Where sources diverged in detail, the transcript was treated as the primary source of record.

2. Origin and Positioning of PlayNest

The Play group was founded seven years ago on the thesis that individual creators were becoming their own media channels — a thesis originated by the founder (Gabriel's father) after two decades at Globo. PlayNest itself launched with a deliberately creator-first sequence: for its first eighteen months it worked exclusively with creators, offering educational content and tools with no monetization and no brand-facing product at all. Only after that period did the company launch PlayNest Business, a white-label platform that lets individual brands (cited examples include Magalu and Casas Bahia) run their own branded environment to manage campaigns, creators, and training.

This origin story is a structural difference from Creator Ads' model: PlayNest's brand-facing product is three years old, but it sits on top of a creator relationship the company had already been building for a year and a half before any monetization began. The interviewee described this as an intentional inversion of what most platforms in the category do — building for brands first and treating creators as inventory.

3. Market Growth and the Budget-Location Insight

Gabriel Paes Leme estimated that the market shift — brands starting to understand creators as media in their own right — began roughly two years ago. He was not aware of a published projection for how fast the 2.7% figure (Exame, 2025, citing Kantar Ibope Media and Statista) will grow, but expects a meaningful jump, pointing to digital ad investment having already overtaken television as a leading indicator of the underlying shift.

The most useful structural insight from this interview concerns **where** creator budget sits inside a brand's organization. According to the interviewee, brands typically operate two distinct budget pools: a

marketing/content/social budget, which is where creator spend is currently drawn from, and a separate media budget, which remains largely centralized with traditional advertising agencies. The 2.7% figure, in this framing, is less about creators being unproven and more about which budget line creator spend has historically been funded from — a distinction that did not surface in the Creator Ads interview.

4. Client Profile, Minimum Investment, and Service Model

PlayNest works with a minimum campaign investment in the R\$30,000–R\$50,000 range, split across two commercial formats: a scale/volume/agility format with no brand-side pre-approvals (minimum R\$30,000, ideal R\$50,000), and a fuller-control format with complete approval flows for creators, scripts, and content (minimum R\$50,000). Below roughly R\$10,000–20,000, the interviewee argued, running a campaign directly rather than through any platform simply makes more sense — the platform only earns its overhead above that volume.

As with Creator Ads, there is no self-service today: every brand is assigned a dedicated Customer Success contact, and all campaigns run through that internal team. The reasoning given was explicitly about preserving control and quality, and avoiding brands taking actions on the platform that PlayNest would not endorse — a more risk-averse framing than Creator Ads' own self-service reasoning, which centered on internal product-readiness rather than brand risk.

5. Creator-Side Relationship and Acquisition

Creator relationship management was presented as PlayNest's clearest differentiator. Creators are treated as a client segment in their own right, not just as campaign inventory: a dedicated Customer Success team gives ongoing feedback on content quality, and a closed WhatsApp community of 3,000 creators (split into three moderated groups of up to 1,000 each) is opened periodically to let creators interact directly. Roughly 20 people across brand-care, creator-CS, and creator-support functions maintain this relationship layer.

Acquisition today is fully organic: about 300 new creators join per day, primarily through referrals and organic discovery on Instagram. Paid acquisition and proactive outbound sourcing are reserved for specific, regionalized, or niche campaigns where the existing base does not cover the profile needed (the example given was sourcing male creators in a specific content niche for a targeted campaign). The company deliberately caps supply growth to match brand demand: the base is held at roughly 110,000 creators, and further organic growth is intentionally not pursued at this time, since onboarding more creators than there is campaign demand for would leave newcomers unable to monetize and create frustration.

6. Technology and Platform Evolution

This interview surfaced far less product/technology depth than the Creator Ads conversation, consistent with the interviewee's role as the business lead rather than a technical operator. What was shared: the original PlayNest Creators app was built as a web view wrapped in a native shell, which drew criticism for feel and performance; the team is now rebuilding it as a fully native application. The interviewee also described a general product philosophy of building only in response to observed pain points rather than speculative features, and noted that day-to-day technology and product leadership has since passed to a specialized co-founder/partner.

Note. No equivalent to Creator Ads' SmartMatch/Guardian/Whisper stack, automated pricing formula, or mid-campaign budget-reallocation mechanics was discussed in this interview. This is most likely a gap in what this particular conversation covered, not necessarily an indication that PlayNest lacks comparable systems.

7. Agency Role and Group Structure — Second Validation of Hypothesis A

The Play group itself is structured as four separate companies: PlayNest (a hybrid platform-plus-service offering, not a pure self-serve product); Play9, a casting agency representing roughly 80 exclusive creators; Playground, a content/social/influence agency; and Play Action, a production company. The interviewee was careful to distinguish these from **traditional advertising agencies** (he named Publicis, OMG/IPG, and WPP as the three largest in Brazil), which centralize a brand's media investment and distribute it across vendors while owning the creative strategy.

Asked directly how PlayNest relates to these traditional ad agencies, the answer mirrors what Creator Ads reported: agencies are frequently PlayNest's clients. When an agency holds the budget, it hires PlayNest as a vendor; when the brand holds the budget directly, the brand contracts PlayNest and the agency is compensated separately, if at all. Either way, agency intermediation of PlayNest deals is described as common. This is a second, independent confirmation of Aurora's **Hypothesis A — Agency as Client**, now corroborated by two unrelated market leaders using very different product models.

8. Cross-Comparison: Creator Ads vs. PlayNest

Table 1

Side-by-Side Comparison of the Two Interviews

Dimension	Creator Ads (Kevin Ramlow)	PlayNest (Gabriel Paes Leme)
Origin / thesis	Built around programmatic-style micro/nano buying at scale.	Built creator-first: 18 months of pure creator education before any brand product existed.
Minimum investment	Exists; sized to prove the micro/nano-pool thesis, prioritizes top media spenders.	R\$30k–50k, split into two commercial formats by approval level.
Self-service	None today; piloted successfully; exploring agent-first (MCP) for the future.	None today, by deliberate choice, to protect quality and brand risk.
Automation depth discussed	High: named AI products (SmartMatch, Guardian, Whisper), dynamic pricing formula, mid-campaign boost reallocation.	Low: conversation stayed at business/relationship level; app rebuild (web view → native) was the only technical detail shared.
Creator relationship	Framed as a support/ticket-resolution problem (Whisper agent).	Framed as a community/coaching relationship (CS feedback, 3,000-person WhatsApp community).
Agency role	Agencies are clients/bridges, not competitors (with a manual-scale exception).	Agencies are frequent clients/intermediaries; distinguished from the group's own casting/content agencies.

Note. Both interviews independently confirm Aurora's Hypothesis A on agencies. The clearest divergence is depth of automation discussed, which likely reflects interviewee role (engineer vs. founder) more than actual product capability.

9. Cross-Check Against Aurora's Initial Personas

Table 2

Persona Assumptions Compared to This Interview's Findings

Persona	Assumed pain	What this interview shows
Marina (brand)	Wants predictable, programmatic-style pricing for nano/micro creators.	Not directly addressed; pricing logic per creator was not discussed at this level of the organization.
Duda (creator)	Wants fast, transparent, fair payment and to be treated as more than inventory.	Strong partial validation: PlayNest explicitly treats creators as a client segment with dedicated coaching and community, though payment speed/transparency specifically was not discussed.
Renata (agency)	Fears disintermediation; wants multi-client/white-label management with protected margin.	Confirmed again: agencies act as intermediated clients. Notably, PlayNest's own core product is itself white-label for brands, a mechanic Aurora could examine for the agency-facing side.

Note. Persona pains as originally documented in Personas Iniciais (Marina, Duda, Renata).

10. Implications for Aurora

- **Hypothesis A now has two independent confirmations.** Across two structurally different companies (engineering-led vs. relationship-led), agencies consistently function as intermediated clients rather than being disintermediated. This should be treated as settled for planning purposes.
- **The creator-experience gap is real and may be underserved even by category leaders.** PlayNest treats this as its core differentiator precisely because most competitors don't; this suggests Aurora's own creator-side experience (support, coaching, community) is a genuine lever, not a commodity feature.
- **Minimum-investment thresholds vary meaningfully by player** (PlayNest's R\$30k–50k vs. Creator Ads' implied higher, top-spender-first floor). This spread suggests there is room for Aurora to position deliberately along that axis rather than assuming a single market-standard minimum.
- **The two-budget insight (media budget vs. marketing/content budget) is a useful GTM lens.** Knowing which budget line a prospective brand's creator spend actually comes from could sharpen how Aurora frames its pitch and who it should be selling to inside a brand's organization.
- **No self-service exists at either player, for different reasons.** Creator Ads cites product readiness; PlayNest cites brand-risk control. Both leave the fully-managed model as the market default today, which is either a barrier to differentiate against or a validation that full-service remains what large accounts actually want.

11. Limitations

This analysis rests on a single interview with one PlayNest executive, conducted at a strategic rather than operational level; figures such as the 300 daily creator signups, the 110,000-creator base, and the 20-person support structure are self-reported and were not independently verified. Because the conversation stayed largely at the business and relationship level, this report cannot speak to PlayNest's technical or automation

maturity with the same confidence as the Creator Ads analysis — that comparison in Section 8 should be read with that asymmetry in mind, not as evidence that PlayNest's technology is less advanced.

References

Exame. (2025). *Media investment in influencer marketing in Brazil* [Data from Kantar Ibope Media and Statista, as cited in interview preparation materials].

Paes Leme, G. (2026, September 15). *PlayNest interview* [Personal interview transcript]. Conducted by K. Souza.

Ramlow, K. (2026, September 11). *Creator Ads interview* [Personal interview transcript]. Conducted by K. Souza.